The language of values-based cooperation and rules-based order in Asia masks a more pragmatic approach to partnership. Both countries have significant interests in maintaining freedom of navigation through the sea lanes of the Indian Ocean and the South and East China Seas, given that the bulk of global trade remains seaborne and the majority of India's and Japan's hydrocarbon imports pass through these sea lanes. Both countries have since 2013 increasingly also coordinated external investment policy in the Indo-Pacific region as competitors to Beijing's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). In July 2017, India announced the creation of an Asia Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC) in partnership with Japan that will develop connectivity between Asia and Africa, in a move that many saw as a response to China's deep inroads across both continents.[28] Although New Delhi certainly does not have Tokyo's deep pockets when it comes to external investment and aid – and Tokyo in turn struggles to match Beijing's deeper pockets – India does enjoy considerable goodwill in the developing world ranging from Africa to Southeast Asia,[29] where much of the geo-strategic competition over infrastructure and connectivity will play out in coming decades.

India and Japan have also laid the foundation for policy coordination in realms other than economic and security cooperation, namely in the arena of multilateral institutions and global governance. A prominent example in this vein is their common interest in securing permanent seats on a reformed United Nations Security Council in the future. India and Japan have in the past collaborated with Germany and Brazil on this front as part of the so-called Group of Four (G-4) in an effort to lobby the five permanent members of the UNSC (the P-5) for greater representation. Although these efforts have brought few gains – largely due to Beijing's opposition to Japan's membership – the experience of institutional partnership and joint efforts at coalition-